on the street who were supervising the loading of factory goods onto a train for shipment out. Smoothing the creases in her coat, she showed her work pass to the guard and explained that she was there to collect something from the sick bay. The guard motioned her to a door at the end of the hall on which a red cross had been painted on a white background.

Léa knocked. No answer. She tried again and heard footsteps as the door opened.

“Come in,” a man said.

If not for his eyes, she wouldn’t have recognized him as the man from last night. They were brighter than she remembered, maybe because he wasn’t wearing glasses. He was taller and thinner, but she’d only seen him in a heavy wool coat. He signaled for her to follow him.

The sick bay had beds lined up in every available space. A corridor led to what she assumed were more rooms. As Léa followed him along a path between the beds, the sour smell of urine and sweat rose in the air. Some patients coughed and wheezed. She counted a dozen beds, maybe more, and wondered if he worked alone. It seemed too much for one person. He opened a door, stood aside, and waited for her to enter first.

It felt strange to stand alone in a room with a man since it had been months since she worked late with Maître Mallon at the office. He had been her boss, while this man, well, she didn’t even know his name. Léa tugged at the sleeve of her coat and glanced around the narrow space: a ceramic sink in a corner with a rickety wooden table next to it on which rested a stethoscope, thermometer and a handful of kidney-shaped basins; a cabinet with shelves and drawers stood against a wall; and farther along, she spotted a desk with a chair and lamp. To her delight, a typewriter sat on the desk. Her heart jumped a little because she was sure it was a Hermes, just like the one in Maître Mallon’s office. She went to it, running her fingers along the round metal-rimmed keys and it suddenly brought her back to Orléans before the Occupation and happier times.

She looked a little closer at the keys and saw a German keyboard, with umlauted vowels on the right and the Eszett, or sharp S, where the question mark had been.

“That dreaded machine arrived a month ago,” the man said. “I detest it!”

“How can you? It’s a marvelous invention.”